

Chapter 5: Grief

Nerys, 8 Years Ago

Eric was dead.

That day, Nerys could swear the Lumis had grown a little dimmer. No one could really explain what happened; according to the Duskwatch members who'd been on duty at the time, he'd just suddenly grabbed an axe and rushed the barrier. Some of the guards had tried to stop him, but by the time they realized he wasn't stopping, it was too late to pull him back.

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Eric... was dead.

Nerys could barely keep herself together most days. If it weren't for Kraekon, she'd probably have hidden herself away at home for days on end. Instead, she'd forced herself to keep going. She picked up extra shifts at the distributary to keep her mind occupied when Kraekon was at work and made herself try twice as hard when he wasn't—if she hadn't already been considered fragile before, people would say she was running herself ragged.

As for Kraekon, well... He hadn't taken Eric's death particularly well. Nerys couldn't have predicted exactly how he'd have been affected, though. On the day of Eric's memorial, Flavio had approached Nerys on behalf of Kraekon.

He and Kraekon had been talking, he said. She'd wiped her eyes and braced herself for a conversation; it wouldn't be an easy one—not here, not now. Whatever this was about, she would have to seem strong—for Kraekon's sake.

That was when Flavio explained. Apparently, Kraekon had come to Flavio for some advice after work one day. He told him that he was considering a different internship—moving away from blacksmithing. He wanted to be a part of Duskwatch.

Just like Eric.

Nerys steeled herself, trying to let Flavio finish explaining. Flavio said that Kraekon didn't really explain well *why* he wanted to switch—something about wanting to protect the city. But Flavio suspected there was more.

Out by the edge of the room, Nerys could see Kraekon peak around the corner, watching to see how the conversation was going.

Flavio suspected—and Nerys couldn't help but agree—that maybe Kraekon really just wanted to feel close to his dad once again. To hold onto what little was left of him, of his legacy. To try to be like him.

Regardless of his true feelings, Kraekon had sought out Flavio to get his approval to change his apprenticeship, and, once he'd gotten his blessing, he'd then asked for Flavio's assistance. Kraekon didn't think Nerys would listen to him, but if Eric's best friend asked—if he'd explained that it was actually a really safe job and Kraekon would be looked after well—then maybe she'd agree. And between the two of them, surely they could find someone they'd trust to help him apprentice under...

Nerys gave a half-hearted smile. Eric had always been headstrong, but he'd rarely thought through his plans like that. Kraekon's plan sounded more like something she would have done, back when she was younger. He truly was their son—*both* of theirs. Despite her fear of the dark and her wariness at letting her son spend time near it, she couldn't say no. She couldn't let go of Eric, and she certainly wouldn't tell their son to do that.

Nerys gave her approval, looking over at Kraekon around the corner and giving him a nod, before she thanked Flavio for his help. He told her it was nothing, that Kraekon and Nerys were like family. Eric and Flavio had been close for years, and in the wake of Selene's death, Flavio had grown even closer to their family. Flavio promised that, if any of them ever needed anything—even if Kraekon just needed some advice—that he'd be there for them—if not for their sake, then at least for Eric's.

As they left the memorial that day, heading to visit the Duskwatch headquarters, Nerys gripped Kraekon's hand tightly and reflected. She was thankful for Flavio's help; she knew he was trustworthy, that he'd drop whatever he was doing to come help if he needed to. But Nerys couldn't help but wonder: what could he possibly hope to do if Kraekon started hearing the shades too? She'd known for years that Eric thought he could hear them. And if that was what ultimately drove him mad... then nothing she'd said to him had been enough. She may have kept him around for longer, but there was nothing she could do to stop the voices, to convince him they were harmless.

Nerys glanced off into the darkness as they drew closer, a mix of hatred, disgust, and desperation welling inside her. Maybe if she had been able to hear them too... maybe if she knew what they said, what they jeered and threatened at her love... then maybe she could have saved him. Maybe she could have made a real difference.

Maybe I could have protected them.

